

The Hansard

A WEEKLY DIGEST OF THE PROCEEDINGS OF THE PARLIAMENT OF THE UNITED KINGDOM

Deny, deny, deny. Then approve to spy

Under-16s are to be banned from holding social media accounts — Snapchat, TikTok, YouTube, Instagram, Facebook, X — on the Australian model, with regulations promised by the end of the year and the ban in force in early 2027. The striking part is the about-turn: this spring the Commons voted an under-16 ban down (307 to 173 in March, with more than a hundred Labour MPs abstaining), and in December the Prime

Minister called himself “personally opposed” to a blanket ban — yet the statement uses the very discretionary power MPs granted instead, to bring the very ban they declined. And the consequence runs well past teenagers: to keep under-16s out, platforms must age-check everyone — adults included — an age-verified, identity-checked internet the Free Speech Union and privacy campaigners call surveillance by another name. It was the week’s defining

story, and it came wrapped in a re-buke: the Deputy Speaker opened by recording the Speaker’s displeasure that the Prime Minister had unveiled it from Downing Street, not the House. Around it ran a tech-and-online-safety cluster — disinformation, online hate speech, a cyber-security bill — while the division bell rang nine times, most loudly to send the Railways Bill out of the Commons and up to the Lords.

THE DIVISIONS, CLOSEST FIRST

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THE MOST-ASKED SUBJECTS

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THE FEATURE

The ban they denied three times, and the age-check it puts on everyone

The week’s set-piece was a Government statement, not a bill. Under-sixteens are to be banned from holding social media accounts on the Australian model. The named platforms are Snapchat, TikTok, YouTube, Instagram, Facebook and X. Regulations are to be laid and voted on by the end of the year. The ban comes into force by early 2027. Messaging apps such as WhatsApp are exempt. Livestreaming and stranger-contact would be barred for under-sixteens, and sexualised “companion” chatbots for under-eighteens. Ofcom must define “highly effective age assurance”, and enforcement would fall on the platforms, not the children. The politics is sharper than the cross-party welcome suggested. This spring the Commons voted an under-sixteen ban down by 307 to 173 in March, with over a hundred Labour Members of

Parliament abstaining. It preferred to hand ministers a discretionary power under the Children’s Wellbeing and Schools Act rather than be bound to act. In December the Prime Minister called himself “personally” opposed to a “blanket ban”. The statement uses that very power to deliver the very ban, which is why the Shadow Secretary called it the Prime Minister’s “shot at a legacy... something that six months ago he said he was personally opposed to”. And before any of it, the Deputy Speaker recorded the Speaker’s displeasure that the announcement had been made from Downing Street rather than the House. One consequence outlasts the politics. To keep under-sixteens out, every user has to prove their age. That points to an identity-checked internet critics already call surveillance by another name.

A SAMPLE OF THE WEEK’S QUESTIONS

Mobile Phones: Children · Graham Stuart, Conservative
Whether the Department has assessed the most popular smartphone applications used by 8 to 14-year-olds after (a) 21:00 and (b) 23:00.

THE ANSWER Protecting children online is a priority for the Secretary of State and this government. That is why we published the ‘Growing up in the Online World’ consultation, accompanied by a National Conversation on 2 March 2026.

THE MOST ACTIVE

Mike Wood asked more written questions than any other Member of Parliament this week with 118. Keir Mather answered the most with 161.